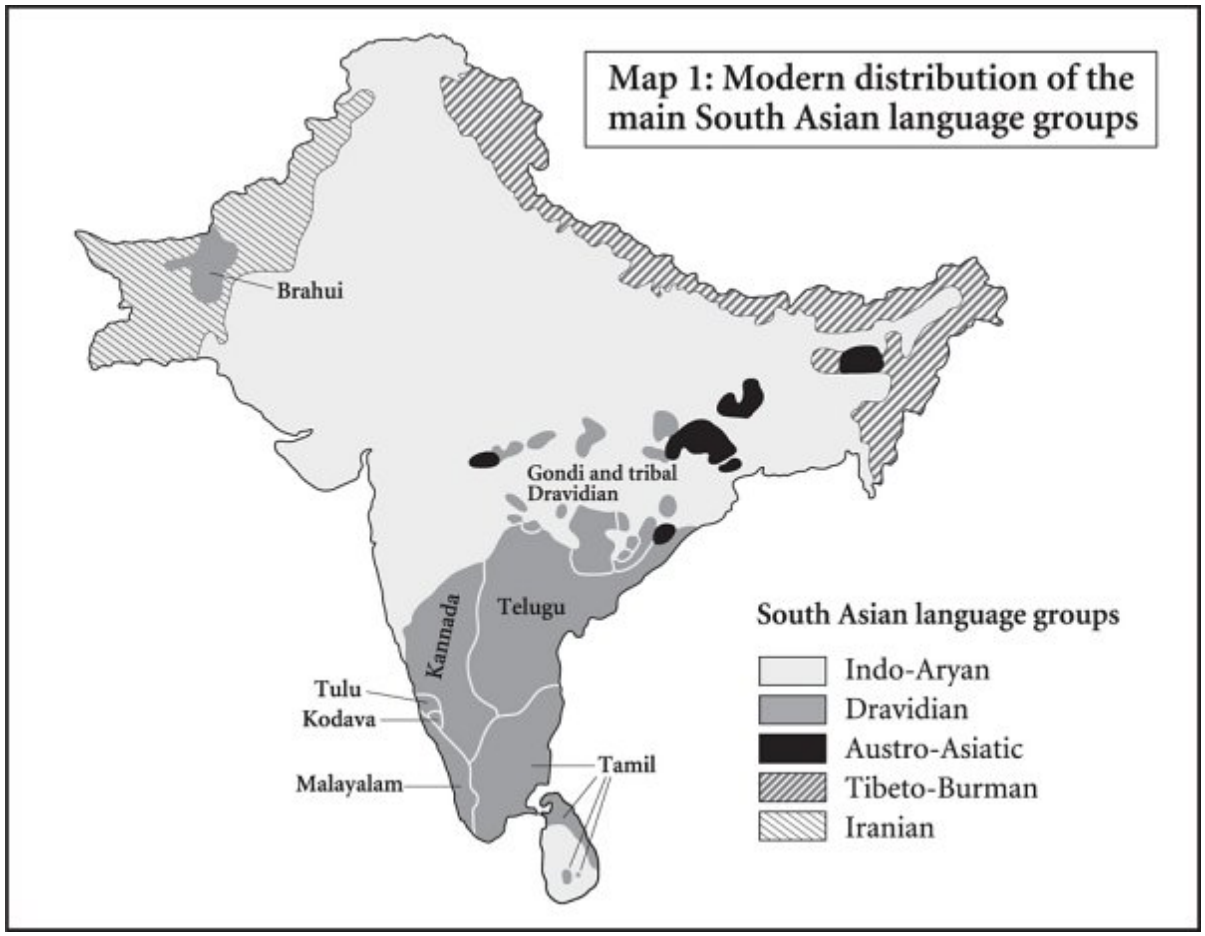
Hindi, Gujarati, Marathi and Punjabi; just less than a quarter speak languages that are Tamil-based in origin, whether Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Kannada or Tulu. The remaining 2 per cent is divided between the so-called Austro-Asiatic group and the Tibeto-Burman group of languages spoken along India's borders abutting Tibet and Burma.



The modern distribution of the two main South Asian language groups – Indo-Aryan and Dravidian-Tamil – along with three smaller groups: Austro-Asiatic, now spoken only in small pockets in central and eastern India; Tibeto-Burman, spoken along the Indian subcontinent's pre-1947 Himalayan and eastern borders; and Iranian, spoken on the western borders of Pakistan. (Adapted from 'Language families and branches', in *A Historical Atlas of South India*, OUP, 1992.)

Packed into one solid triangle in the deep south are the Dravidian language speakers, just as you would expect, with scattered pockets of outriders extending along the Vindhyan